Assignment: Alternative Story Structures

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Objective:
Create one **Short Film Story** and one **Video Game Story** for each of the following alternative story structures:

1. Non-Linear Structure
2. Parallel Structure
3. Circular Structure

Your stories should be:

- Short and easy to understand
- Commercially appealing ("sellable")
- Suitable for modern audiences
- Expandable into a short film or indie game project

A. Non-Linear Structure

Short Film Story: "The Final Edit"

Opening Scene:
A frantic video editor is cutting footage of a high-end luxury wedding, but they are visibly terrified, staring at a specific frame of the bride.

The story jumps between different moments in time:

- **6 months earlier:** The editor is hired by a mysterious, ultra-wealthy client to document their life.
- **2 weeks earlier:** The editor captures a tense, whispered argument in the background of a gala.
- **1 day earlier:** A break-in at the editor's studio; files are stolen, but one backup remains.
- **Present day:** The editor keeps replaying the wedding footage, looking for anomalies.

Twist:
The audience finally discovers the bride in the footage is an advanced AI clone replacing a missing tech CEO, and the editor accidentally filmed her glitching.

Story Structure Used:
The story uses a **non-linear structure** because events are not shown in chronological order. It begins in the present with the editor already terrified, then jumps back to earlier events to slowly reveal why the footage is dangerous. Each flashback adds a new clue. The audience pieces together the mystery alongside the main character, making the final reveal more suspenseful and satisfying.

Logline:
A terrified video editor races to decode stolen wedding footage after discovering that a missing tech CEO may have been replaced by an advanced AI clone.

Why it works:
Mystery + Tech Paranoia + High Concept Reveal

Video Game Story: "The Last Hand"

Genre: Roguelike Deckbuilder / Noir Thriller

The Hook: A gambler sits at a high-stakes poker table in a smoke-filled backroom, betting their own memories instead of cash chips.

The story jumps between:

- **The Past (Gameplay Jumps):**
- A shady back-alley trade to get a rare card.
- A brutal betrayal of a trusted partner.
- A high-stakes heist of a locked corporate safe.
- A desperate deal made in the dark.
- **Present Day:** The high-stakes card game where each played card forces the player to relive those memories out of order, changing their understanding of how they reached this final table.

Twist:

The player eventually learns the opponent across the table is the Devil, and they are trying to win back their own soul after selling out their partner.

Story Structure Used:

The game uses a **non-linear structure** because the player relives past events out of order through the cards played during the final poker match. Each memory reveals a new part of the gambler's story and gradually changes the player's understanding of how they reached the table.

Logline:

A gambler betting memories instead of money must survive a deadly poker game against the Devil to win back their soul.

Why it works:

Dark psychological thriller wrapped around a highly addictive, trending gameplay loop.

B. Parallel Structure

Short Film Story: "The Bid"

Storyline A:
An ambitious young chef prepares an exclusive dinner for an anonymous billionaire investor who could fund their dream restaurant.

Storyline B:
A desperate whistleblower races against time to sell a hard drive containing stolen tech data to a mysterious buyer at the same high-end restaurant.

The stories alternate throughout the film.

Final Reveal:
The billionaire used the dinner as a cover to meet the whistleblower, and the chef accidentally delivers the hidden hard drive inside the final dessert course.

Story Structure Used:

The story uses a **parallel structure** because it follows the chef and the whistleblower at the same time. Their separate storylines meet in the final reveal when the hard drive is delivered inside the desert.

Logline:

An ambitious chef's dream dinner turns dangerous when a secret data deal unfolds at the same restaurant and a stolen hard drive is accidentally served inside the final dessert.

Theme:
Survival, ambition, and the hidden cost of success.

Why it works:
High tension, fast pacing, and a stylish modern setting.

Video Game Story: "Echoes of the Wild"

Genre: Cinematic Survival Adventure

The game alternates between:

Character 1:
A wildlife photographer trying to survive and document animals in a vibrant prehistoric forest.

Character 2:
A scavenger searching for resources in the ruined version of the same forest in a post-apocalyptic future.

Both characters face different challenges across the same landscape.

The Mechanics:
The player alternates between eras. The photographer plants seeds, marks paths, and alters the landscape, which dynamically creates bridges, safety zones, and resources for the future scavenger to use.

Final Act:
The scavenger discovers the photographer's final time-capsule message and uses it to locate the last clean water source on Earth.

Story Structure Used:

The game uses a **parallel structure** because it follows two characters living in different eras of the same forest. The player switches between the prehistoric past and the post-apocalyptic future. Actions taken by the photographer directly affect the scavenger's journey.

Logline:

A wildlife photographer in the prehistoric past must reshape the landscape to help a future scavenger find the last clean water source on Earth.

Why it works:
The two timelines keep the gameplay fresh and show how actions in the past can shape the future.

C. Circular Structure

Short Film Story: "The Interview"

Opening Scene:
A nervous graduate waits outside an office before a job interview.

The film shows:
Rejection emails
Learning new skills
Freelance work
Mistakes
Building confidence

Final Scene:
The graduate stands outside the same office again.

Everything looks identical.

Difference:
This time, the graduate is not waiting for a job interview. They confidently walk into the room as the founder of a company meeting a potential investor.

Explanation of the Story Structure Used:

The story uses a **circular structure** because it begins and ends outside the same office. The setting remains the same, but the graduate has changed from a nervous applicant into a confident founder.

Logline:

After repeated job rejections, a nervous graduate returns to the same office-not as an applicant, but as a founder meeting an investor.

Theme:
Growth, resilience, and creating your own opportunities.

Why it works:
Simple, motivational, and satisfying, with a clear final twist.

Video Game Story: "The Lighthouse"

Genre: Survival Adventure

Opening:
The player begins inside an abandoned lighthouse during a violent storm.

The journey includes:
Exploring flooded islands
Collecting supplies
Repairing boats
Rescuing survivors
Defeating sea creatures

Ending:
The player returns to the same lighthouse.

Difference:
The lighthouse is now fully restored, guiding ships toward a new coastal settlement.

Story Structure Used

The game uses a **circular structure** because it begins and ends at the same lighthouse. The location stays the same, but it changes from an abandoned shelter into a symbol of hope and progress.

Logline:

After surviving a flooded world, a lone survivor returns to the abandoned lighthouse where the journey began and transforms it into a beacon for a new settlement.

Theme:
Hope, rebuilding, and leadership.

Why it works:
Strong visual identity, simple survival mechanics, and an emotional ending.

Bonus Challenge:

Create concept art sketches, storyboards, or a simple game flowchart for one of your stories.

A. Non-Linear Structure

Short Film Story: "The Final Edit"

